

Getting started with **Claude Code**, no coding required

Got a prompt from me and no idea where to paste it? You're in the right place. Six short steps, and you'll have an AI assistant that works on the files on your computer and actually knows you.

 About 20 minutes Mac or Windows No terminal, no code

Interactive version: rogre1.github.io/ai byby.ro/claude-code-start

1

So what is Claude Code?

One minute of context that saves an hour of confusion

You probably know Claude's chat: you ask, it answers, and you copy the answer somewhere else. **Claude Code is Claude with hands.** Instead of only answering, it **does the work**: it opens files on your computer, creates documents, organizes folders, builds landing pages, converts files and runs whole tasks for you from start to finish.

Regular chat

"Write copy for my landing page"
→ You get text. You copy it, paste it and design it yourself.

Claude Code

"Build me a landing page using the logo in this folder"
→ **It builds the file**, adds the logo, opens a preview and fixes things based on your notes.

And the best part: despite the name, **you don't need to know how to code.** You talk to it in plain English, like you would with a personal assistant.

2

What you need before you start

Three things. That's it.

- **A Mac or Windows computer.** You can check in from your phone later, but you start on a computer.
- **A paid Claude plan.** Claude Code doesn't work on the free plan. The basic plan, **Pro**, costs \$20 a month (\$17 a month if you pay yearly), and it's plenty to get started. If you use it a lot and keep hitting the usage limit, you can upgrade to **Max**.
- **One task that's been bugging you.** Seriously. The best way to learn is with a real task: clean up a folder, build a page, make sense of a spreadsheet.



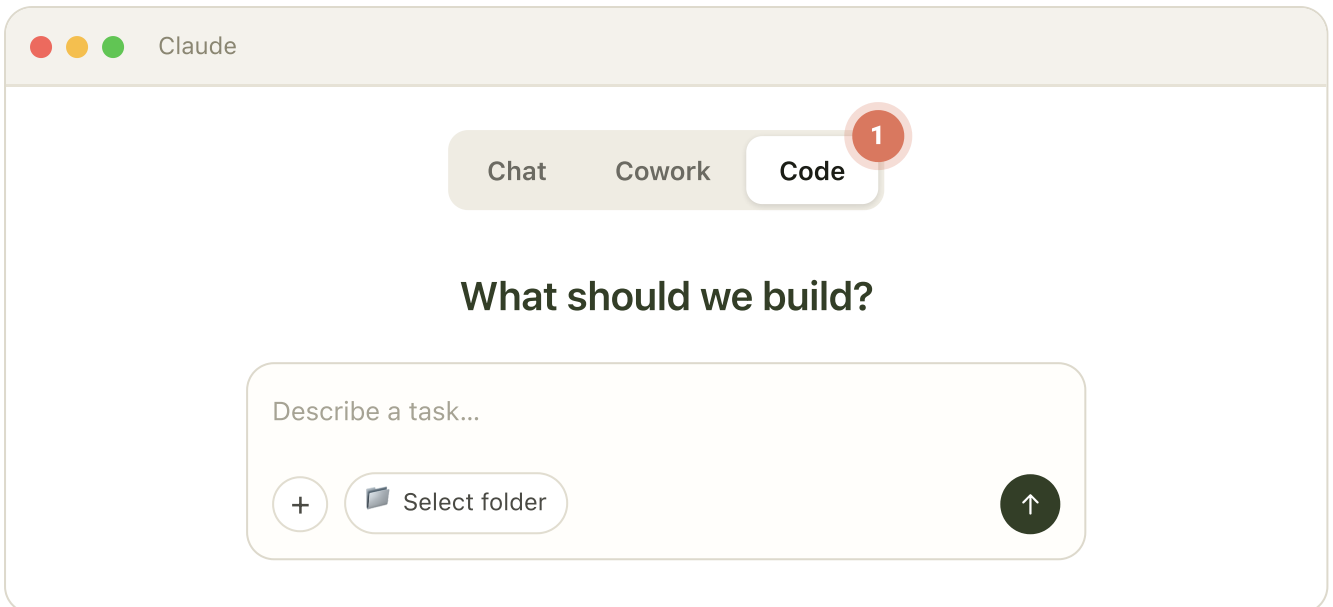
Already paying for Claude chat? Great, it's **the same plan**. You don't pay twice.

3

Install the app

No terminal, no commands. Just like any other app.

- 1 Go to claude.ai/download and download the Mac version.
- 2 Open the downloaded file and drag the Claude icon into your **Applications** folder.
- 3 Open Claude and sign in with the account that has your plan.
- 4 At the top you'll see three tabs: **Chat**, **Cowork** and **Code**. Click **Code**. You're in.



1 The **Code** tab. This is where you use Claude Code. (Chat is the regular chat you already know.)

Illustration. The app gets updated from time to time, so small design details may look different.



Getting an error when you open the Code tab? It usually means you signed in with a free account. Sign out and sign back in with the account that has your plan.

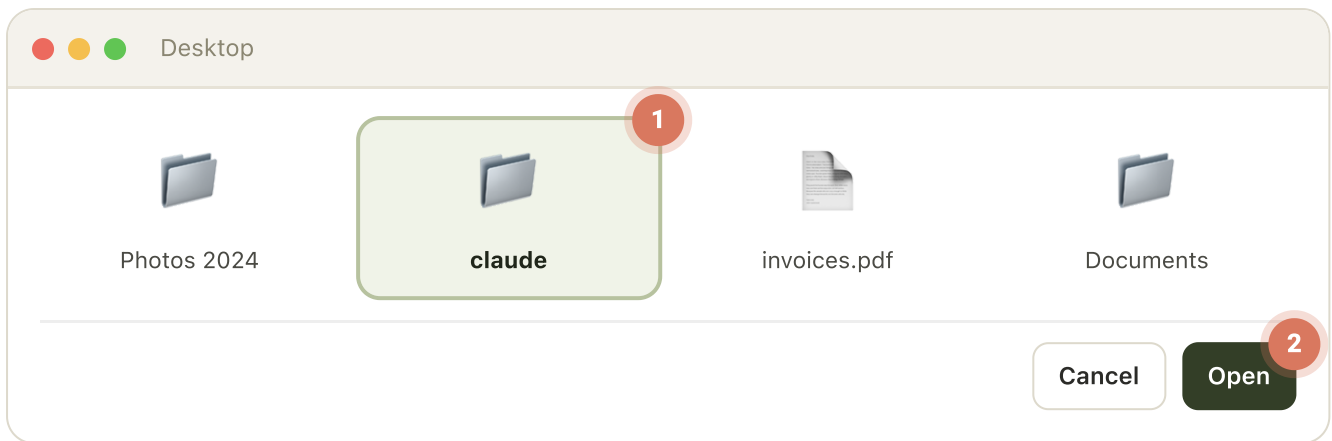
4

Pick a work folder

The most important step nobody explains

Claude Code always works **inside one folder on your computer**. It can read, change and create anything in that folder. Anything outside it, it won't touch without asking. Think of it like giving an assistant the key to one room, not the whole house.

- 1 Create a new folder on your Desktop and call it something like **claude**.
- 2 Put the relevant stuff in it: your logo, a doc about your business, images, spreadsheets. **Copies only**, never the originals.
- 3 In the app, under the message box, click **Select folder** and choose that folder.



- 1 The folder you made just for Claude.
- 2 Click **Open**, and the folder name shows up next to the message box.



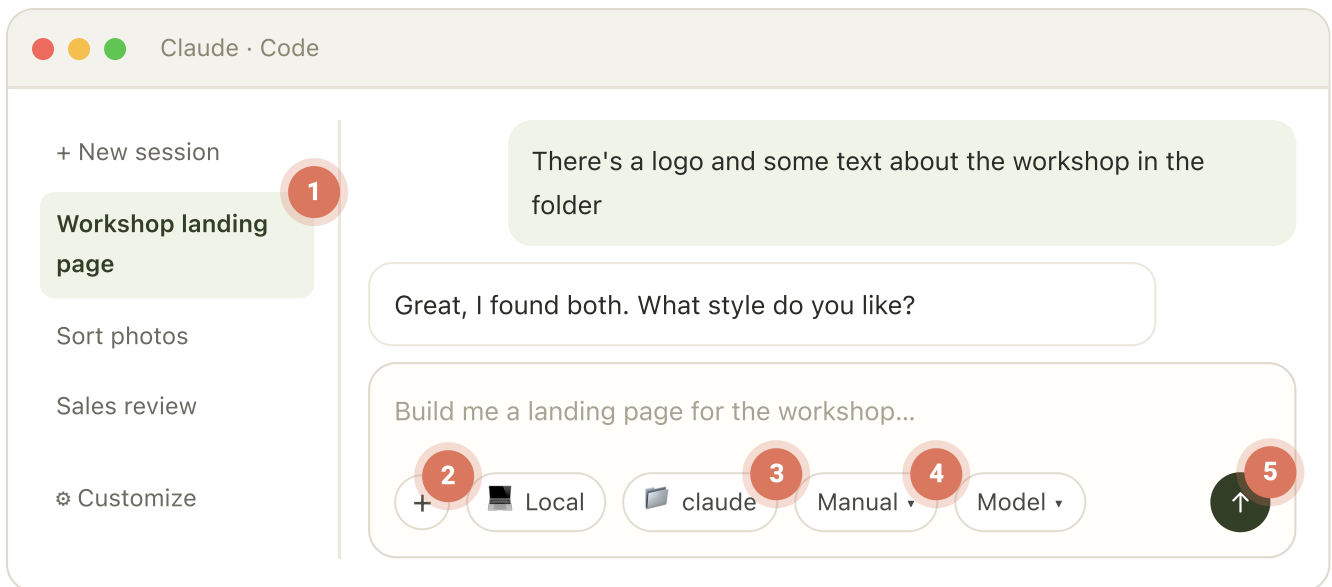
Why a separate folder? So Claude doesn't get lost in thousands of unrelated files, and doesn't accidentally change something important. You can make one folder per project: one for content, one for your business, one for your website.

5

Your first chat

What each button does, and what to do when an approval box pops up

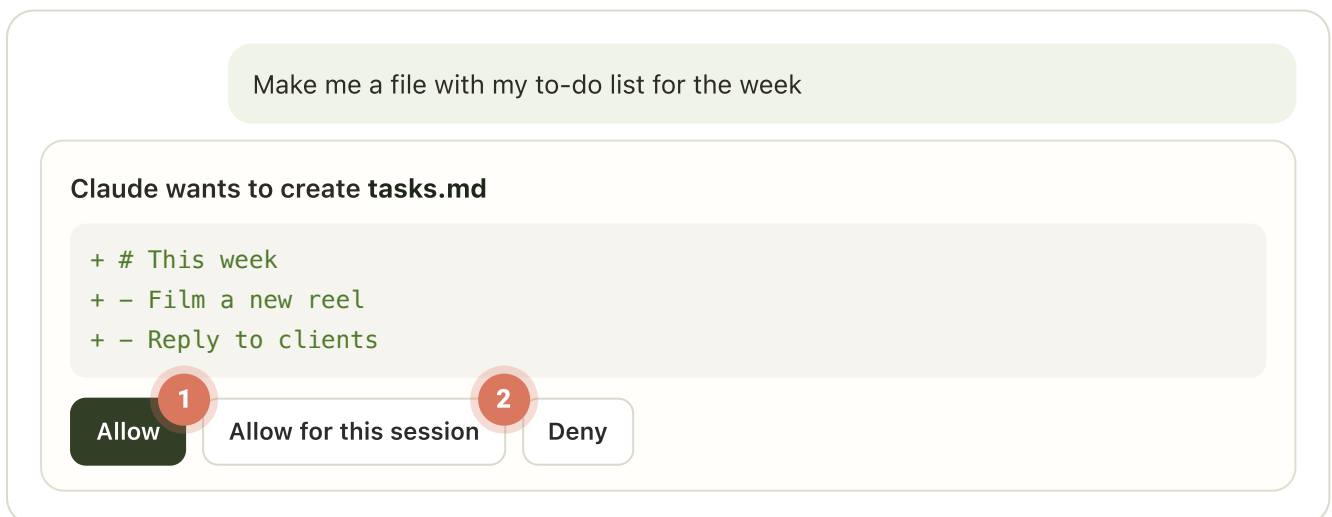
Here's the message box. It looks like a regular chat, but it has a few buttons worth knowing:



- 1 **The sidebar:** every session (conversation) is saved here. You can go back to any of them and keep going.
- 2 **The plus button:** attach files and images, run skills, connect Google and more. We'll get there.
- 3 **The folder** you picked in the last step.
- 4 **Permission mode:** how much freedom Claude gets. Explained right below.
- 5 **Send.** While Claude is working, it turns into a stop button. You can stop it at any moment.

The approval box: don't panic

Before Claude changes a file or runs an action, it **stops and asks**. It looks roughly like this:



- 1 **Allow:** approve this one action only.
- 2 **Allow for this session:** approve this kind of action until the conversation ends, so it stops asking every time.



My rule: read the one line telling you what it wants to do. Creating or editing files in your folder? Allow. Deleting something, or an action you don't understand? Click **Deny** and type "explain what this does first".

Modes: how much freedom to give it

Button number 4 sets the permission mode:

Mode	What happens	When to use it
Manual	Asks before every change and action	At the start. It's how you learn what it does
Accept edits	Edits files on its own, only asks before other actions	Once you trust it and want things to flow
Plan	Changes nothing. Just explores and shows you a plan to approve	Big tasks. Highly recommended!
Auto	Works on its own while a safety check reviews each action in the background	When you're experienced and ready to let go



The trick that changed how I work: big task? Start in **Plan** mode. Claude asks questions, shows you a plan, you tweak it, and it only starts building once you approve. It saves so many rounds of fixes.

Try it now: your first prompt

Pick the one that fits you best, copy it and paste it into the message box:

For creators

PROMPT TO COPY

I create Instagram content about [your topic]. Build me a content calendar for next month as a spreadsheet in this folder: date, reel idea, a hook for the first 3 seconds, and caption text. Before you start, ask me 3 questions about my audience.

For business owners

PROMPT TO COPY

I run a [type of business]. Build me a simple, beautiful landing page as a single HTML file that presents my service and has a WhatsApp button. If there's a logo in this folder, use it. When you're done, open it in my browser so I can see it.

For the curious

PROMPT TO COPY

Look at the files in this folder and tell me what's in it. Then suggest 5 useful things you could do with them, from easy to advanced, and explain each one in a sentence.

6

Teach Claude who you are

This is how it stops sounding like a robot and starts working like you

Claude starts every new conversation with a blank slate. It doesn't know what your business is, how you write, or what you can't stand. There are four ways to introduce yourself, from most to least important:

1. CLAUDE.md: your intro page

It's a plain text file that sits in your work folder. **Claude reads it automatically at the start of every conversation**, without you having to mention it. Whatever is in there, it simply knows.

The easiest way to create one? Ask Claude:

PROMPT TO COPY

Create a CLAUDE.md file in this folder. Interview me first: ask me one question at a time about who I am, what my business is, who my audience is, how I like things written, and what you should never do. At the end, sum it all up in a short, organized file.

About me

Dana, bridal makeup artist in Austin. 8 years of experience.

My audience

Brides aged 25 to 35. Most inquiries come from Instagram.

How to write for me

- Warm, everyday English, first person
- Short sentences, no fancy words
- No emojis at all

Good to know

- Brand colors: dusty rose and cream
- The logo is in logo.png

An example CLAUDE.md. You can open and edit it any time, or just tell Claude "add to CLAUDE.md that...".

2. Memory: "remember that..."

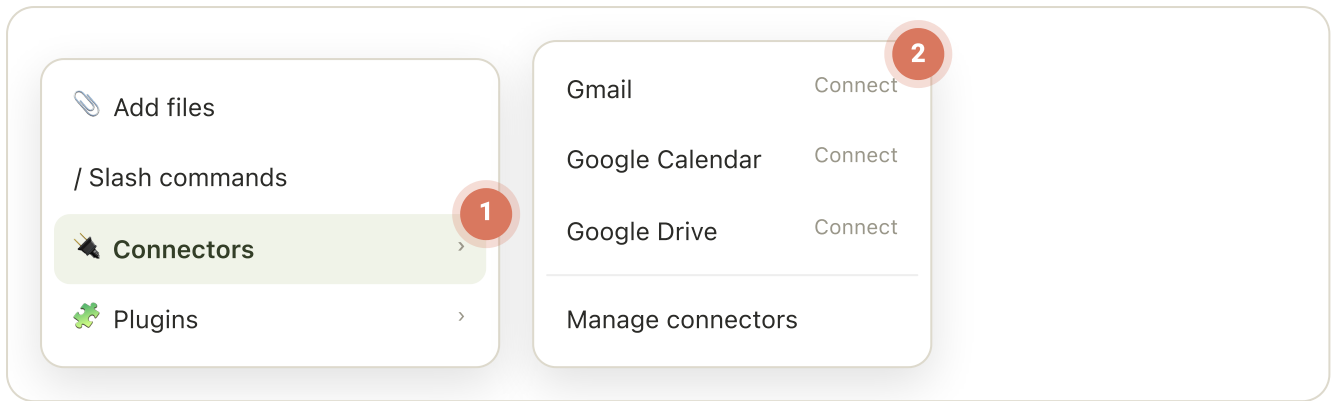
Claude Code can keep notes for itself between conversations. When you correct it on something that keeps coming up, just say: **"Remember that I always want short headlines."** Next time, it already knows.

3. Files in your folder

Claude can read anything you put in your work folder: your logo, a brand doc, examples of posts that did well, a price list. Want to point it at a specific file? Type @ and the file name, or drag a file or image into the message box.

4. Connectors

You can connect Claude to the services you already use: **Gmail, Google Drive, Google Calendar, Notion, Canva** and more. Then it can read emails, check your calendar or save files to Drive.



1 Click + next to the message box and choose **Connectors**.

2 Pick a service, click **Connect** and sign in. That's all.



What not to put in: passwords, card details and ID numbers. Not in CLAUDE.md, not in the folder, not in the chat. It doesn't need them, and that's not the place for them.



Skills: teach Claude a task once

The thing that turns it from a general assistant into your specialist

A skill is a **recipe**. A set of instructions for a task you do over and over, written once. From then on, Claude just knows how to do it exactly the way you like.

An example from my own work: I have a skill for writing reel scripts. It holds everything I've learned: how to build a hook, where to put a "re-hook" in the middle, what my voice sounds like. Now I type "write me a reel script about..." and Claude **pulls out the skill on its own** and follows my method, without me explaining it again.

So what's the difference between CLAUDE.md, memory and a skill?

	What it is	When Claude reads it	Best for
CLAUDE.md	An intro page	Always, at the start of every chat	Who you are, your business, your style
Memory	Small notes	When they're relevant	Preferences and small corrections
Skill	A recipe for a task	Only when that task comes up	Repeat processes: scripts, quotes, posts

Because a skill only loads when it's needed, it can be long and detailed, with examples and attached files, without weighing down every conversation.

How to use a skill

- **Automatically:** just ask for the task. If a skill fits, Claude pulls it out on its own.
- **Manually:** type `/` in the message box and a list of all your skills opens up. Pick one and type your task after it.

1

/reel-script

Reel script, my way

/price-quote

Price quote

/weekly-post

Weekly post

/reel-script

about the most common prompt mistake

+

2

↑

- 1 Type `/` to see all your skills.
- 2 Pick one, type the task and send.

Where to get skills

The best way: have Claude build one for you

Did a task with Claude and, after a few fixes, the result came out perfect? That's exactly the moment to say:

PROMPT TO COPY

Turn what we just did into a skill, so next time you do it exactly like this without me having to explain. Include every correction I gave you along the way. Save it as a personal skill so it works in all my folders.

Install a ready-made one

Click **Customize** in the sidebar (or **+**, then **Plugins**, then **Add plugin**). You'll find ready-made skills and plugins there, including ones from Anthropic itself: working with Excel, PowerPoint, PDFs and more. One click to install.

A **plugin** is simply a bundle: a few skills, connectors and settings that come together. If you find one for your field, it saves a lot of setup.

Someone sent you a skill (me, for example)

A skill is just a folder with a file called `SKILL.md`. The easiest way: drag the file or folder into the message box and type "**Install this as a personal skill.**" Claude puts it in the right place.

If you want to know where they live: personal skills are saved in

`~/ .claude/skills`, and skills for a specific project are saved inside that project's folder, in `.claude/skills`.



A skill is a set of instructions Claude follows. **Only install skills from sources you trust.** Not sure? Ask Claude: "Read this skill and tell me what it does before you install it."

What a skill looks like inside

There's no magic here. It's plain text, with a description line at the top that helps Claude know when to use it:

skills / weekly-post / SKILL.md

name: weekly-post

description: Writes my weekly Instagram post. Use when I ask for a post, caption or Instagram text.

When writing a weekly post:

1. Open with a question my audience asks themselves
2. Three short points, one per line
3. End by inviting people to save the post
4. Hashtags only at the end, never in the middle

Example of a post that did well: see example.md

The top part (between the three dashes) is the **description**. The more precise it is, the better Claude knows the right moment to use the skill.



Skills get better over time. Didn't love something in the result? Once you've fixed it, type: "Update the skill so that from now on...". Every fix is saved for good.



More good-to-knows

Not needed on day one, but you'll be glad you know



New chat, or keep going in the old one?

New task, new session (**New session**). A long conversation with lots of topics makes Claude confused and slow. Your old sessions stay in the sidebar, so you can always go back and continue any of them.



How to stop or correct it mid-task

Click the stop button and it stops right away. You can also just type a correction ("wait, no red") and send it while it's working. It reads the message and changes course.

Which model to pick

Next to the send button there's a model picker. The default is great for most tasks. A stronger model is better for complex work, but it also eats more of your usage.

Usage limits, and how not to run out

Every plan has an allowance that refills every few hours. The small ring next to the model picker shows how much you've used. To save: one session per task, focused requests, and don't attach huge files you don't need.

Slash commands worth knowing

Type `/` to see the full list. A useful one to start with: `/init`, which creates a CLAUDE.md automatically based on what's in your folder. The others each have a short description in the list.

Tasks that run on their own

You can ask Claude to do something on a schedule, like "every morning at 8, put together a summary of my important emails". It creates a scheduled task that runs by itself (as long as your computer and the app are open).

You can send it images and screenshots

Drag an image into the message box. "Here's a screenshot of my site, fix what's circled in red" works great. So do PDFs and spreadsheets.

Aa

Glossary

Tap a term to see what it means

Prompt

The message you write to Claude. The clearer and more detailed it is, the better the result.

Session

One conversation. Each session has its own history and folder, and it's saved in the sidebar.

Work folder

The folder on your computer where Claude works. It only sees and changes what's inside it.

Permission

The approval Claude asks for before it changes a file or runs an action.

Plan mode

A mode where Claude changes nothing. It just explores and shows you a plan to approve.

CLAUDE.md

Your intro file. Claude reads it automatically at the start of every conversation.

Memory

Notes Claude keeps for itself between conversations, like your preferences and corrections.

Skill

A saved recipe for a repeat task. It only loads when that task comes up.

Plugin

A bundle of several skills, connectors and settings you install in one go.

Connector (MCP)

A link between Claude and an outside service like Gmail, a calendar or Notion. MCP is the technical name.

Slash command

Anything that starts with / in the message box: skills and built-in commands.

Tokens

The "units" your usage is measured in. Long conversations and big files use more.



Tips and common mistakes

What I wish someone had told me on day one

- **Give context, not just a command.** "Write a post" gets you something generic. "Write a post for brides who are on the fence about a makeup trial, in a warm tone" gets you something that sounds like you.
- **Ask it to ask you questions.** "Before you start, ask me what you're missing" is the single most useful sentence there is.
- **Work on copies.** Claude is careful, but it can change and delete files. Don't hand it the only folder of your wedding photos.
- **Big task? Plan mode.** Plan first, build second.
- **Didn't come out right? Don't start over.** Tell it exactly what's wrong. It improves really fast from feedback.
- **Nailed it? Make it a skill.** That way every win stays with you.

That's it, you're ready 🎉

Now go back to the prompt I sent you, paste it into the message box in the Code tab, and watch the magic happen.

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